

Run of show

Names _____ Date _____ Venue _____

WEDDING 101
THE WORKSHEET

TIME	WHAT	MIN	WHO CUES IT	NOTES
	Ceremony	30	officiant, MC	
	Cocktail hour, photos	60	caterer, photo	
	Guests seated	15	MC, caterer	
	Grand entrance	10	MC	
	First dance	5	MC	
	Welcome or blessing	5	MC, the couple	
	Toasts	10	MC	
	Dinner	60	caterer	
	Table visits, floor opens	30	the couple	
	Cake cutting	5	caterer, MC, photo	
	Parent dances	10	MC	
	Open dancing		MC	
	a moment inside the dancing			
	a moment inside the dancing			
	Last song	5	MC	
	Send-off	10	MC, planner	

The rules I use

1. The cocktail hour covers the photos. Ask the photographer for the number.
2. Fifteen minutes to seat a room; twenty-five for two hundred people or another room.
3. Toasts before dinner, under fifteen minutes all together.
4. Plated two courses about an hour, a buffet forty-five; ten minutes more for every fifty guests over a hundred.
5. Cake about thirty minutes after the last plate.
6. Parent dances right after the cake, while the room is seated.
7. Last song five minutes before the music has to end; line everyone up for the send-off ten minutes before that.

The faint numbers are my defaults. Write over them. Whatever is left after the formalities is your dance floor; ninety minutes or more is what a five-hour night usually gives it.

Dance floor minutes Music ends Everyone out by

Sunset

Four sample clocks

The same night run through my default rules from four ceremony times. Two speakers at four minutes, plated two courses, a mixed pace, the music ending five to five and a half hours after cocktails.

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2 o'clock ceremony

2:00	Ceremony
2:30	Cocktail hour
3:30	Guests seated
3:45	Grand entrance
3:55	First dance
4:00	Welcome
4:05	Toasts, then air
4:20	Dinner, then air
5:25	Table visits
5:55	Cake
6:00	Parent dances
6:10	Open dancing
7:55	Last song
8:00	Send-off

Dance floor 105 minutes.
Daylight the whole way; the send-off is in the light most of the year.

4 o'clock ceremony

4:00	Ceremony
4:30	Cocktail hour
5:30	Guests seated
5:45	Grand entrance
5:55	First dance
6:00	Welcome
6:05	Toasts, then air
6:20	Dinner, then air
7:25	Table visits
7:55	Cake
8:00	Parent dances
8:10	Open dancing
9:55	Last song
10:00	Send-off

Dance floor 105 minutes. My default; the clock most Saturdays run on.

5 o'clock ceremony

5:00	Ceremony
5:30	Cocktail hour
6:30	Guests seated
6:45	Grand entrance
6:55	First dance
7:00	Welcome
7:05	Toasts, then air
7:20	Dinner, then air
8:25	Table visits
8:55	Cake
9:00	Parent dances
9:10	Open dancing
10:55	Last song
11:00	Send-off

Dance floor 105 minutes. Sunset lands in cocktail hour or dinner from May to August: plan the step-out.

6 o'clock ceremony

6:00	Ceremony
6:30	Cocktail hour
7:30	Guests seated
7:45	Grand entrance
7:55	First dance
8:00	Welcome
8:05	Toasts, then air
8:20	Dinner, then air
9:25	Table visits
9:55	Cake
10:00	Parent dances
10:10	Open dancing
11:25	Last song
11:30	Send-off

Dance floor 75 minutes with an 11:30 stop. This is the clock that squeezes the floor; a first look or a shorter cocktail hour buys some back.

Sunset, New Bedford, Massachusetts

DATE	SUNSET	LAST LIGHT	DATE	SUNSET	LAST LIGHT
Jan 1	4:24 PM	4:55 PM	Apr 1	7:09 PM	7:37 PM
Jan 15	4:38 PM	5:09 PM	Apr 15	7:24 PM	7:53 PM
Feb 1	4:59 PM	5:29 PM	May 1	7:42 PM	8:12 PM
Feb 15	5:17 PM	5:45 PM	May 15	7:56 PM	8:28 PM
Mar 1	5:34 PM	6:02 PM	Jun 1	8:12 PM	8:45 PM
Mar 15	6:50 PM	7:18 PM	Jun 15	8:20 PM	8:54 PM

DATE	SUNSET	LAST LIGHT	DATE	SUNSET	LAST LIGHT
Jul 1	8:22 PM	8:56 PM	Oct 1	6:26 PM	6:53 PM
Jul 15	8:17 PM	8:50 PM	Oct 15	6:03 PM	6:31 PM
Aug 1	8:02 PM	8:33 PM	Nov 1	5:39 PM	6:07 PM
Aug 15	7:44 PM	8:13 PM	Nov 15	4:24 PM	4:53 PM
Sep 1	7:17 PM	7:46 PM	Dec 1	4:14 PM	4:45 PM
Sep 15	6:53 PM	7:21 PM	Dec 15	4:14 PM	4:46 PM

Local clock, EST or EDT as the date falls. Golden hour starts an hour before sunset; with no first look the ceremony should end about two hours before sunset for daylight photos, an hour with a first look; outdoors, end thirty minutes before sunset at the latest. Sunset moves about a minute a day, so check the exact minute for your date. Source: US Naval Observatory, 41.6362 N, 70.9342 W, calendar year 2027; within a few minutes for the South Coast, the South Shore, Cape Cod, and Rhode Island.